



Land at Sladburys Lane, Little Clacton

Biodiversity Net Gain Assessment

Client: Stanfords

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1.0 SUMMARY

1.1 The site (located at NGR: TM 19061 16815) was found to comprise a small grass field with a significant area of compacted hard core used for parking and storage of materials. The field surrounded on three sides to varying degrees by mature hedges with trees. Outline planning permission is being sought to erect 29 residential dwellings on the site, accessed via Sladbury's Lane to the south east.

1.2 The assessment found the site to comprise the following habitats:

Other neutral grassland (g3c)

Artificial unvegetated, unsealed surface (u1c)

Developed land, sealed surface (u1b)

Tall forbs (g3, 16)

Individual trees

Bramble scrub (h3d)

Sparsely vegetated urban land – ruderal / ephemeral (u1f, 81)

Native hedge with trees and ditch (h2a, 11, 50)

Native hedge with ditch (h2a, 50)

1.3 The proposals are expected to result in the loss of 5.65 area habitat Units, equivalent to a decrease of 53.27%. In order to achieve 10% Biodiversity Net Gain, it will be necessary to purchase 6.72 offsite area habitat units. 40m of species rich hedging could be provided on site in order achieve 10% net gain in linear habitat units. There are no watercourse habitats on site.

1.4 No irreplaceable habitats were identified on site, and no such habitats will be adversely affected by the proposals



2.0 INTRODUCTION

Instruction

- 2.1 This report has been prepared by Liz Lord following instruction by Ms. A Cox of Stanfords to undertake a Biodiversity Net Gain (BNG) Assessment of land to the north west of Sladbury's Lane, Little Clacton, Essex.

Site Proposals

- 2.2 Outline planning permission is being sought to erect 29 residential dwellings on the site, accessed via Sladbury's Lane to the south east.
- 2.3 The BNG assessment has been based upon the proposed layout detailed on drawing number 3735 PA-10 dated May 2025 by Duncan Clark and Beckett Ltd, as shown in Appendix 1. Note that any amendments to the overall scheme may require the BNG assessment to be updated where it results in a change to habitats of value. The BNG assessment will require updating as and when detailed soft landscaping proposals are available.

Site Location and Setting

- 2.4 The site lies on the eastern outskirts of Little Clacton, and to the north west of Holland-on-Sea, near Clacton, Essex. It is adjoined to the south and west by existing and new residential dwellings. To the north and east is arable farmland, extending north to the edge of Little Clacton. Sladbury's Lane runs along the south east site boundary.
- 2.5 The wider landscape is dominated by residential dwellings, interspersed with small pockets of grass / scrub parkland, commercial buildings and caravan parks, with arable fields extending north east. Grazing pastures associated with Holland Brook are present c.1km to the east.

Aims

- 2.6 This report has been written in accordance with the Biodiversity Templates Version 1 produced by the Chartered Institute of Management (CIEEM) (CIEEM, 2021). In accordance with the client brief and the requirements of the Local Planning Authority, this assessment aims to:
- 2.6.1 Serve as a Biodiversity Net Gain Design Stage Report;
- 2.6.2 Calculate and present baseline data classifying the type and value of habitats prior to, a post development, giving consideration to habitat distinctiveness, condition and strategic significance in accordance with current development proposals;
- 2.6.3 Present evidence to show that data has been classified in a reliable manner;



- 2.6.4 Specify data collection methods and any limitations in a transparent manner in order that each step may be repeatable by another party;
- 2.6.5 Detail the steps necessary to achieve BNG on-site wherever possible; however off-site contribution measures will be considered as an alternative option if required, particularly where the scale of a development proposal does not allow for realistic or achievable creation.

Relevant Policy and Legislation

- 2.7 The Environment Act 2021 makes provision for biodiversity gain to be a condition of planning permission in England, with a minimum 10% BNG mandatory from 12th February 2024 (large sites) and 2nd April 2024 (small sites). The Environmental Improvement Plan (DEFRA, 2023) sets out goals for improving the environment and leaving it in a better state for the next generation, and is supported by the National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF) (Ministry of Housing, Communities and Local Government 2024), which makes general provisions for the delivery of BNG. The NPPF states that plans should:

- a) “Identify, map and safeguard components of local wildlife-rich habitats and wider ecological networks, including the hierarchy of international, national and locally designated sites of importance for biodiversity; wildlife corridors and stepping stones that connect them; and areas identified by national and local partnerships for habitat management, enhancement, restoration or creation; and*
- b) promote the conservation, restoration and enhancement of priority habitats, ecological networks and the protection and recovery of priority species; and identify and pursue opportunities for securing measurable net gains for biodiversity.”*

- 2.8 The Natural Environment and Rural Communities Act 2006 states that local authorities have an obligation to have regard to the purpose of conserving biodiversity in carrying out their duties.
- 2.9 Locally specific policies set out what strategies need to be taken into account when delivering BNG, and may include Green Infrastructure Strategies and Local Nature Recovery Strategies in order that BNG may contribute to wider nature recovery plans. At the time of writing, a Local Nature Recovery Strategy has not yet been completed for Essex.
- 2.10 Policy PPL4 of the adopted Tendring District Council Local Plan (2022) entitled ‘Biodiversity and Geodiversity’ states that:

“Proposals for new development should be supported by an appropriate environmental assessment. Where new development would harm biodiversity or geodiversity, planning permission will only be granted in exceptional circumstances, where the benefits of development demonstrably outweigh the harm caused and where adequate mitigation or, as a last resort, compensation measures are included, to ensure a net gain, in biodiversity.”



“Proposals for new infrastructure and major development should consider the potential enhanced biodiversity, appropriate to the site and its location, including, where appropriate within Green Infrastructure.”

2.11 The Tendring District Council Local Plan and supported documents (accessed and reviewed on 8th May 2025) do not yet appear to formally require the provision of 10% (or more) Biodiversity Net Gain for new development, however it is recognised that it is now a requirement under the Environment Act (2021). Tendring District Council has now begun the process of reviewing the local plan.

2.12 Tendring District Council's interim BNG guidance originally issued in autumn 2024 (but no longer available online), required the implementation of the national 10% gain for all applicable development sites, with the interim policy stating:

“Alongside the requirements in relation to Biodiversity and Geodiversity set out in Policy PPL4 [of the Council's existing Local Plan], development in Tendring will be subject to the legal and national requirements for ‘Biodiversity Net Gain’ (BNG). For planning applications submitted to the Council on or before 31 March 2027, development proposals that qualify for BNG will be expected to deliver a minimum 10% increase in biodiversity value relative to the predevelopment biodiversity of on-site habitat within the development site to meet the biodiversity objective in line with the national minimum requirement. From 1 April 2027 onwards, the requirement will be a minimum of 20%, as established through this policy.

“The method by which developers are required to calculate the existing biodiversity value of a site and thereafter calculate and deliver BNG are set out in full within national guidance.

“In line with the Biodiversity Gain Hierarchy as set out in legislation and national guidance, the Council will expect as much of the necessary BNG as possible to be delivered on-site (within the red line boundary of a development site), through measures that will be secured through legal agreement and/or planning condition.

“Any residual BNG requirement that cannot be met on-site can be delivered off-site either on land in the control of the developer/landowner outside of the development site (to be tied into a legal agreement and registered), or by the purchase of offsite biodiversity units from a registered site. In both cases the offsite BNG must be allocated to the development and the Council would need to be provided with official certification of registration of that allocation to the development. If developers cannot achieve on-site or off-site BNG, they must buy statutory biodiversity credits from the government as a last resort. The government may then use the revenue to invest in habitat creation anywhere in England.”

2.13 For now, until the local plan is reviewed, Tendring District Council's current BNG guidance simply requires the implementation of the national 10% gain for all applicable development sites.



3.0 METHODOLOGY

Baseline Survey

- 3.1 The BNG assessment has been informed by a daytime site survey carried out on 23rd September 2024.
- 3.2 The survey was based upon the standard methodology for Extended Phase 1 Habitat Surveys (JNCC 2010) and the UK Habitat Classification system (UKHab Ltd 2023). Each habitat was assigned a Primary Code of the Professional Edition of the UKHab Field Key at a minimum of UKHab Primary Hierarchy Level 3, based on the UKHab Habitat Definitions. All habitat types were mapped, with the smallest allowable Minimum Mapping Unit of 5m or 25m² used across the site.
- 3.3 Any references in this report or the accompanying Preliminary Ecological Appraisal report to 'dominant', 'abundant', 'frequent', 'occasional' and 'rare' link directly to the DAFOR scale for measuring vegetation cover, as is referred to in the UKHab classifications, with the corresponding percentage area cover detailed in the table below.

DAFOR term	Species percentage abundance (cover)
Dominant	76-100%
Abundant	51-75%
Frequent	26-50%
Occasional	1-25%
Rare	<1%

- 3.4 Further details including the species and relative abundance of species recorded across various habitats can be found in the accompanying Preliminary Ecological Appraisal by Liz Lord. The PEA also includes an assessment of the site in relation to protected and notable species.

Surveyors

- 3.5 The surveys were carried out by Liz Lord. Liz has been a professional ecologist since 2005, and holds current Natural England licences to survey bats - Class Licence Reg. No. 2015-13305-CLS-CLS; great crested newts - Class Licence Reg. No. 2020-44816-CLS-CLS; and barn owls - Class Licence Reg. No. CL29/00160.



- 3.6 Liz is a full member of CIEEM, and has attended UKHab and CIEEM training courses in 2023 entitled 'Biodiversity Metric V4 Training' and 'UKHab and Biodiversity Net Gain' as well as various BNC webinars. Liz has been undertaking habitat assessments since 2005, and has attended a variety of grass and forb identification courses including most recently three botanical identification courses provided in 2024 by The Species Recovery Trust and 'Botanical Surveys for Development' by Josh Styles. Liz became a River Condition Assessment accredited surveyor in January 2025.
- 3.7 The weather at the time of the surveys was suitable for gathering botanical survey data i.e. dry and clear with light winds

Calculations

- 3.8 The BNG assessment was undertaken using the current Statutory Biodiversity Metric v1.0.3 (available at: <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/statutory-biodiversity-metric-tools-and-guides>), which classifies the habitat parcels onsite to award measurable values to the site known as 'Biodiversity Units'. The metric uses habitat type, area / length, distinctiveness, condition and strategic significance to classify the habitat parcels and calculate unit values.
- 3.9 The assessment was informed by The Statutory Biodiversity Metric User Guide - July 2024 (Defra, 2024a).

Condition Assessment

- 3.10 Where applicable, habitats were subject to condition assessments using The Statutory Biodiversity Metric – Technical Annex 1: Condition Assessment Sheets and Methodology – July 2024 (Defra, 2024b). The results of any such assessments are included within the Appendices of this report.
- 3.11 Where applicable, proposed habitat conditions have been assigned by reviewing the all Condition Assessment Sheets and using these to determine the most realistic and achievable condition upon establishment and appropriate management.

Strategic Significance

- 3.12 Strategic significance i.e. the local significance of the habitat based on its location and habitat type was assessed in accordance with The Statutory Biodiversity Metric User Guide (Defra, 2024a), which gives consideration both to the formal identification of a habitat's local value, and connectivity a habitat may provide.
- 3.13 The relevant categories are shown in Table 1, overleaf. Generally the categories 'Medium' and 'Low' apply to sites such as this where a Local Nature Recovery Strategy (LNRS) has yet to be published.



Table 1: Biodiversity metric strategic significance categories where an LNRS has not yet been published (Defra, 2024a)

Strategic significance category	Score applied in the metric	Description
High <i>(Formally identified in local strategy)</i>	1.15	The habitat type is mapped and described as locally ecologically important within a specific location, within documents specified by the relevant planning authority. If your project delivers the mapped habitat creation, enhancement or restoration actions set out within specified alternative documents, or enhances existing habitat identified within specified alternative documents, locally ecologically important, strategic significance can be recorded as high in the post-intervention sheets. If the specified alternative documents identify existing habitat as locally ecologically important within a specified location, strategic significance may be recorded as high in the baseline. You should record the name of the plan the relevant planning authority specified in the user comments and record that you have used the specified document in your gain plan.
Medium <i>(Location ecologically desirable but not in local strategy)</i>	1.10	This category can be applied when the LPA has not identified a suitable document for assessing strategic significance. Users should: - explain how the habitat type is ecologically important within a specific location - demonstrate the importance of that habitat in providing linkage to other strategically significant locations - use professional judgement
Low <i>(Area / compensation not in local strategy)</i>	1	Where the definitions for high or medium strategic significance are not met.

Limitations and Assumptions

- 3.14 The conclusions in this report are based on the best information available during the report period of survey.
- 3.15 BNG provides a method of measuring change in biodiversity, however these measures are not absolute values, but ways of demonstrating change in the relative biodiversity value both before and after development. It is not possible to capture all features of value within the BNG assessment, and therefore additional weight may be given to features which are not measurable, but are ecologically important nonetheless. This may include positioning of new habitat features to improve local connectivity, buffering an existing offsite habitat of notable value, or providing habitat for local target species.



- 3.16 During the September survey the grassland appeared to have been mown within the last 4-8 weeks, with accumulated cuttings in some places. Whilst the shorter vegetation made the UKHabs survey more difficult, there was sufficient regrowth and low level vegetation remaining to be able to record and identify a significant number of species. Given that historical Google Earth imagery shows the site was in arable production until around 2019/20, and that the species record reflect that of a typical floristically enhanced arable grass margin, the categorisation of the grassland as 'other neutral grassland' in 'moderate' condition is deemed to be reasonable and most likely accurate. The grass cutting is therefore not considered to be a significant constraint to the conclusions and recommendations of this report.
- 3.17 The habitats on site were not found to be degraded at the time of survey, and it was possible to gain an accurate assessment of all of the habitats onsite. The parking areas, spoil pile and storage areas have been implemented in accordance with the relevant permissions for the adjacent housing development, and are therefore not a form of degradation.
- 3.18 No river features are present on site, and therefore no river based assessments have been made.

Mitigation Hierarchy

- 3.19 The current CIEEM guidelines (2018) state that: *"After assessing the impacts of the proposal, all attempts should be made to avoid and mitigate ecological impacts. Once measures to avoid and mitigate ecological impacts have been finalised, assessment of the residual impacts should be undertaken to determine the significance of their effects on ecological features. Any residual impacts that will result in effects that are significant, and the proposed compensatory measures will be the factors considered against ecological objectives (legislation and policy) in determining the outcome of the application."*
- 3.20 In order to minimise the likelihood of any significant negative residual effects on environment features, this assessment has followed the mitigation hierarchy (listed below in order of preference):

Avoidance – measures that avoid harm to ecological features, both spatially and temporally; and may include relocating buildings and altering layouts;

Mitigation – avoidance or minimisation of negative effects through appropriate timing of works, or the provision of mitigation measures within the scheme design which can be guaranteed by condition or similar;

Compensation – measures taken to offset residual effects which result in the loss of, or permanent damage to, ecological features despite mitigation. Compensation does not prevent effects, but may trade losses of biodiversity in one area with measurable gains in another. These are measured by the BNG assessment.



4.0 RESULTS (*Baseline Conditions*)

Baseline Metric Calculations

- 4.1 The metric calculations show a baseline Biodiversity Unit value of 10.62 area units and 3.05 linear units.
- 4.2 Table 2, below, details the pre-development habitats and their Biodiversity Unit value. Figure 1 overleaf shows the location of these habitats within the site boundary.
- 4.3 Photographs of the different habitat areas are provided in the accompanying PEA report.

Table 2: Pre-development area and linear habitat units

Habitat Type	Area (ha)	Distinctiveness	Condition	Strategic significance	Total habitat units
Other neutral grassland	1.2431	Medium	Moderate	Low	9.94
Ruderal / ephemeral	0.0768	Low	Moderate	Low	0.31
Artificial unvegetated, unsealed surface	0.1696	V.Low	N/A - Other	Low	0.00
Developed land; sealed surface	0.0511	V.Low	N/A - Other	Low	0.00
Other neutral grassland	0.0255	Medium	Poor	Low	0.10
Bramble scrub	0.0166	Medium	Condition Assessment N/A	Low	0.07
Rural tree	0.0163	Medium	Good	Low	0.20
Habitat Type	Length (km)	Distinctiveness	Condition	Strategic significance	Total habitat units
Native hedgerow with trees & ditch	0.104	High	Good	Low	1.87
Native hedgerow with ditch	0.053	Medium	Good	Low	0.64
Native hedgerow with ditch	0.045	Medium	Good	Low	0.54



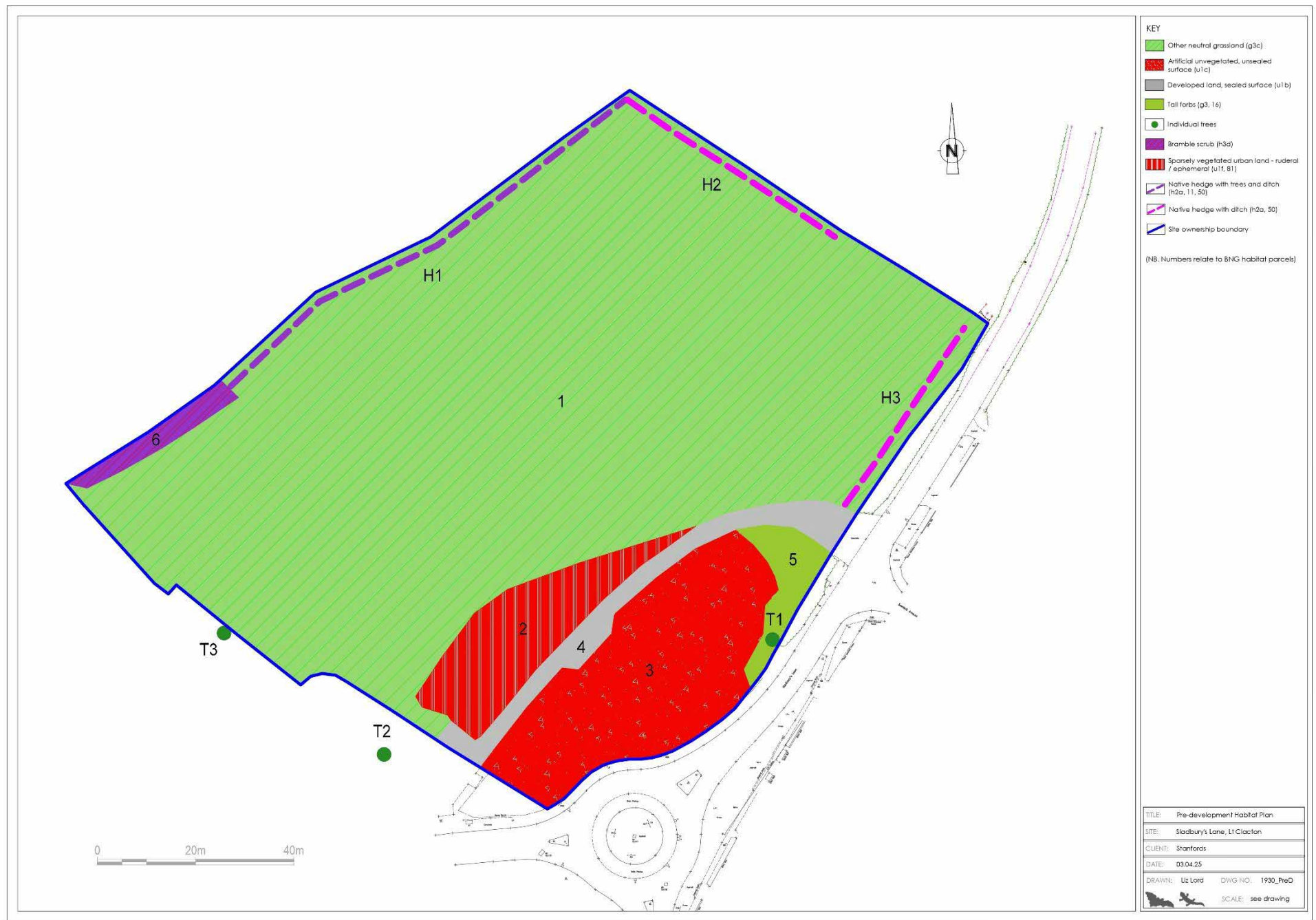


Fig 1: Drawing number 1930_PreD - UK Habitat Classification map for existing area and linear habitats across land at Sladbury's Lane, Little Clacton

5.0 BNG GOOD PRACTICE PRINCIPLES FOR DEVELOPMENT

Metric Principles

- 5.1 Where relevant to the scale of the proposals, the good practice principles set out by CIEEM, CIRIA and IEMA (2016) have informed the use of the metric, and are detailed below, along with justification of how each of the principles has been applied as part of this net gain assessment.

Principle 1 – apply the mitigation hierarchy

- 5.2 Table 3, below, details how the proposals have followed the mitigation hierarchy.

Table 3: Application of the Mitigation Hierarchy

	<i>Requirement achieved</i>	<i>Evidence</i>
<i>Avoid</i>	Yes	The proposals have avoided the loss of all but one mature tree and all of the hedgerows, notably the high distinctive hedge along the north western boundary and a mature oak (now offsite) along the south western boundary. As much grassland as possible has been retained while still maintaining financial viability, by focussing development across unvegetated areas, lightly vegetated areas and hard standing
<i>Mitigate</i>	Yes	Mitigation to ensure the condition of retained grass maintained will include educational signage and management by a company with proven experience managing floristically rich grassland
<i>Compensate</i>	Yes	The loss of areas of other neutral grassland and lower value habitats such as ruderal / ephemeral vegetation compensated for via the creation, enhancement and term management of both on and offsite habitats

Principle 2 – avoid losing biodiversity that cannot be offset by gains elsewhere i.e. avoid impacts on irreplaceable biodiversity

- 5.3 No irreplaceable habitats will be lost as part of the development.

Principle 3 – be inclusive and equitable, achieving Net Gain in partnership with stakeholders where possible

- 5.4 The proposals have taken on board the targets and requirements of the Local Planning Authority, and have targeted the enhancement and creation of both on-site and off-site habitats



Principle 4 – *address risks to achieving Net Gain*

- 5.5 The proposals include the retention of all of the high value boundary habitats i.e. hedgerows, trees and grass margin, which has less associated risk than creating new habitats. Habitats to be created on site will be designed to be easily achievable with relatively basic management skills and tools, more aesthetically acceptable within a urban environment, and realistic as to habitat conditions which can be reached e.g. created other neutral grassland will comprise a tidier species rich flowering lawn mix, rather than a typical wildflower meadow mix throughout. None of the habitats proposed will be complex to create or manage, and there are no known significant risks to their creation or future management.
- 5.6 To achieve 10% net gain, offsite units will need to be acquired, with the risks associated with the necessary habitat creation passed on to the relevant habitat provider. Given that these habitats will need to provide compensation for relatively widespread and easily created / maintained habitats (albeit one of 'medium' distinctiveness), the risks involved with achieving Net Gain via offsite provision are significantly reduced. Arguably the creation of habitats of equivalent greater value by an offsite provider across a larger area of land than can be provided on site also reduces the risks associated with both habitat creation and long term maintenance.

Principle 5 – *make a measurable Net Gain contribution*

- 5.7 It is not possible to achieve 10% measurable net gain on site within a viable housing development of this size. Whilst the outline concepts of the soft landscaping scheme have focussed on the retention of the highest value habitat areas (hedges, trees and adjoining grassland) and creation of complimentary habitats of medium distinctiveness (floristically rich margins, trees and scrub), and a large number of bird and bat boxes will be incorporated into the new dwellings, measurable net gain will only be achieved via the purchase of offsite biodiversity units.

Principle 6 – *achieve the best outcomes for biodiversity*

- 5.8 As detailed above, net gain cannot be achieved on site. Contribution towards offsite biodiversity units in a more appropriate location where habitats can be effectively managed on a larger scale and with wider habitat connectivity will result in a better overall outcome for biodiversity.
- 5.9 Onsite habitat retention and creation will still take place, maintaining as much as possible of the higher value, connective existing habitats for local biodiversity, and providing site scale enhancements for roosting bats, nesting birds and amphibians.



Principle 7 – *be additional– achieve nature conservation outcomes that demonstrably exceed existing obligations (i.e. do not deliver something that would occur anyway)*

- 5.10 Without the proposed works, there would be no provision of nesting sites for house sparrows, starlings or swifts, and no roosting opportunities for bats.
- 5.11 Purchase of offsite units will contribute towards larger scale habitat creation and management which would not have occurred in the absence of such funding. This exceeds any existing obligations, and goes beyond the scale of the development and the predicted impacts upon biodiversity.

Principle 8 – *create a Net Gain legacy*

- 5.12 Bird and bat boxes will be built into the walls of the new dwellings (not externally fixed) so that they remain permanent features. The contribution towards the creation and management of offsite habitat units will ensure the long term provision of habitats across a minimum thirty year period.
- 5.13 Newly planted tree and scrub species will be those which are currently known to be resilient to climate change and are not susceptible to new diseases. For example, ash will not be included in any of the planting, nor will wych elm, larch, Norway spruce, sitka spruce or downy birch, with these five species identified by the Forestry Commission (2023) as being marginal or unsuitable for the future climate in the east of England.

Principle 9 – *optimise sustainability*

- 5.14 Removing cuttings from the grassland for hay (or local habitat piles) will aid in both sequestering carbon and improving habitats for wildlife. The use of flowering lawns in public spaces in place of regularly cut traditional lawns also reduces the use of fuel, with less frequent cutting necessary to allow plants to flower.

Principle 10 – *be transparent, and communicate all Net Gain activities in a transparent and timely manner, sharing learning with all stakeholders*

- 5.15 All correspondence regarding BNG has been between the ecologist, architect and landowner with the aim to achieve all of the BNG principles whilst also enhancing the appearance and value of the new development.



6.0 PROPOSED DESIGN & BNG METRIC

Post-Development Metric Calculations

- 6.1 The metric calculations show a proposed Biodiversity Area Unit value of 4.96, resulting in a decrease in Area Units of -53.27%.
- 6.2 There is currently no change in the Biodiversity Linear Unit value of 3.05, however 10% net gain in Linear Units could be easily achieved on site with the planting of 40m of species rich hedging.
- 6.3 Table 4, below, details the proposed post-development area habitats and their Biodiversity Unit values. Table 5 details the proposed post-development linear habitats and their Biodiversity Unit value.
- 6.4 Figure 2, overleaf, shows the location of these habitats within the site boundary, laid over the proposed development layout.

Table 4: Post-development area habitats

Habitat Type	Retained, created or enhanced	Area (ha)	Distinctiveness	Condition	Strategic significance	Total habitat units
Other neutral grassland	Created	0.082	Medium	Moderate	Low	0.55
SJDS	Created	0.055	Low	Moderate	Low	0.13
Mixed scrub	Created	0.0116	Medium	Moderate	Low	0.08
Vegetated garden	Created	0.2683	Low	Condition Assessment N/A	Low	0.52
Developed land; sealed surface	Created	0.426	V.Low	N/A - Other	Low	0.00
Developed land; sealed surface	Created	0.3379	V.Low	N/A - Other	Low	0.00
Urban tree	Created	0.1751	Medium	Moderate	Low	0.54
Other neutral grassland	Retained	0.3853	Medium	Moderate	Low	3.08
Bramble scrub	Retained	0.0166	Medium	N/A	Low	0.07



Table 5: Post-development linear habitats

Habitat Type	Retained, created or enhanced	Length (km)	Distinctiveness	Condition	Strategic significance	Total habitat units
Native hedgerow with trees & ditch	Retained	0.104	High	Good	Low	1.87
Native hedgerow with ditch	Retained	0.053	Medium	Good	Low	0.64
Native hedgerow with ditch	Retained	0.045	Medium	Good	Low	0.54

Hard landscaping features for biodiversity

6.5 In addition to the planting proposals, the following enhancement features will be provided:

6 no. Habitat house sparrow triple terrace boxes (or similar) will be built in to the northern or eastern façades of six garage dwellings (1 no. terrace per dwelling);

6 no. bat boxes will be provided on site, ideally built into gable end walls at a height of 3-6m and facing between south east and south west;

2 no. Habitat starling boxes will be built in to the northern or eastern façades of two dwellings (1 no. box per dwelling), at a height of 3m or more, and ideally in a garage wall; and

9 no. swift nest boxes will be built in to the gable ends of three of the tallest new buildings (groups of 3 no. boxes per building) at heights of 4-6m

Full details of the box designs and locations are provided in the accompanying PEA report.



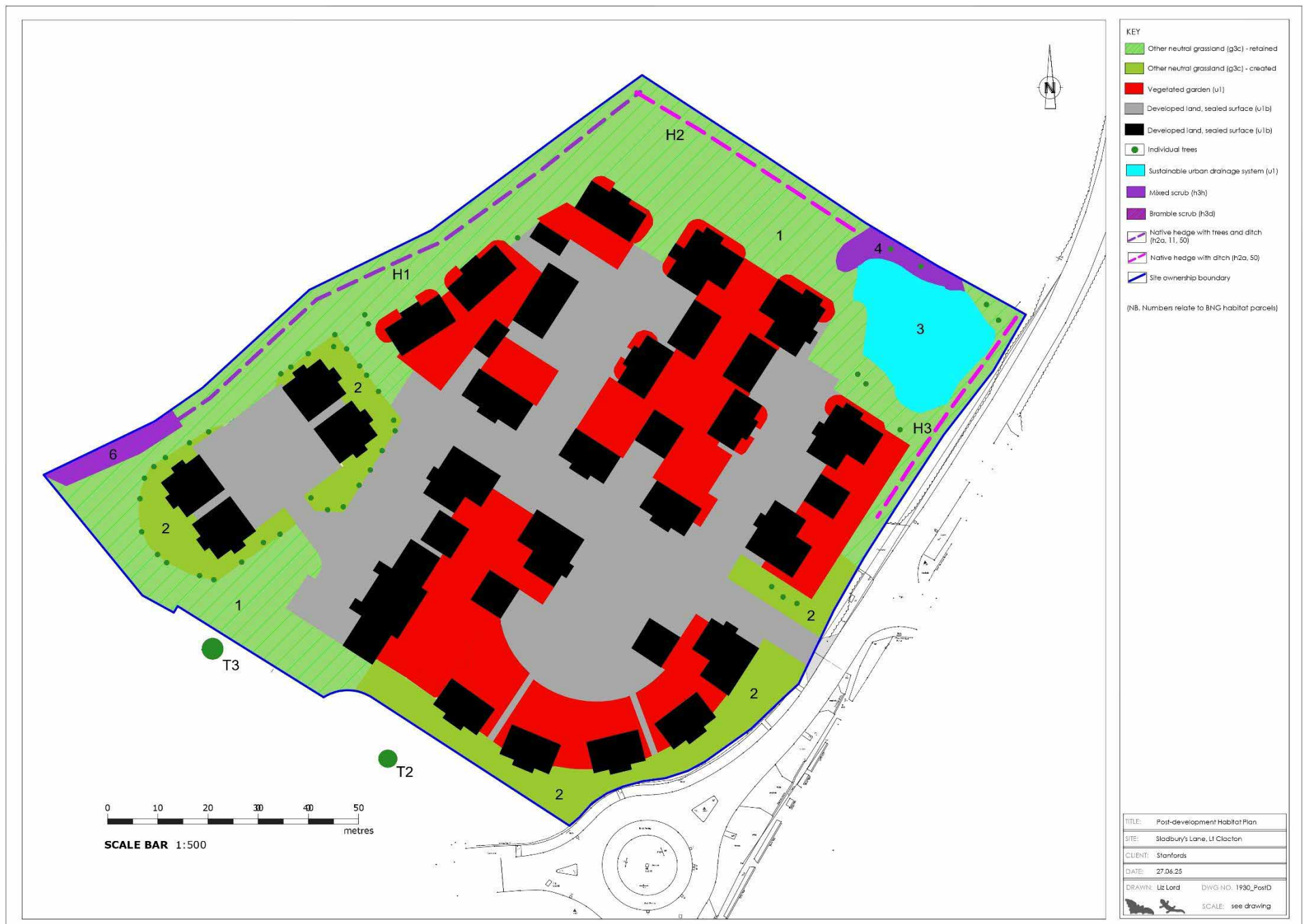


Fig 2: Drawing number 1930_PostD - UK Habitat Classification map for proposed area and linear habitats across land at Sladbury's Lane, Little Clacton

7.0 PROJECT IMPLEMENTATION & CONSTRUCTION PLAN

Implementation Plan

- 7.1 The soft landscaping scheme will be secured by a planning condition. An Implementation Plan by way of a Habitat Management and Monitoring Plan (HMMP) will be provided to ensure the delivery of the onsite biodiversity units. No habitat management is required for the vegetated garden units.
- 7.2 A HMMP for the offsite biodiversity units will be provided as part of a future planning condition. It is not necessary to produce an HMMP at this stage, since it is not yet known where the offsite habitats will be purchased, or what habitats they will be. These details will be addressed as part of a planning condition, and presented in a Biodiversity Net Gain Plan.

On-site Grassland Maintenance

- 7.3 The existing Other Neutral Grassland will be cut at least once an always with arisings removed, from late summer onwards. More frequent cutting and removal of arisings will be carried out between September and March, with longer grass margins retained rotationally in specific areas to provide pockets of habitat for reptiles. No cutting will take place between April and the end of July, with a 'hay' cut carried out between August and September after flow have had a chance to set seed. Thistles, dock and nettles will be spot treated with weedkiller or hand pulled as necessary.

On-site Grassland Creation

- 7.4 The new areas of other neutral grassland will be created via the sowing of flowering lawn mix suitable for the local soil type. Ideally this would be sown across subsoil or very shallow topsoil, but will use a mix suitable for establishment across former arable land i.e. in relatively fertile soil conditions. Long term management will include cutting and removing arisings every 4-6 weeks to enable the low growing plants to flower. Thistles, dock and nettles will be spot treated with weedkiller or hand pulled as necessary.

On-site Shrub and Tree Planting

- 7.5 All tree and shrub planting will be native, and appropriate for the location and long term management of the site e.g. blackthorn will not be planted as a scrub species, to avoid potential for blackthorn suckers to spread across grassland in the future. Trees and shrubs will not be planted close to the southern banks of the SUDS pond, to prevent future issues with shading, but may be used on all other banks to provide valuable habitat, disguise features, hibernacula and to discourage public access to the water.



Timetable for Implementation

- 7.6 All existing hedges, trees and retained grass margins will be protected by fencing for the duration of construction works.
- 7.7 Grassland creation will commence in the autumn or spring closest to completion of construction works, with the pond likely created during initial large earth and drainage works.
- 7.8 Planting of trees and shrubs will be carried out during the November to March winter plant season.
- 7.9 The developer will be responsible for ensuring the delivery of the new habitats, with a management company – with a proven record of managing floristically rich grassland – employed in the long term to manage the public open space.
- 7.10 Educational signage will be used to encourage an interest in, and respect and responsibility for, the habitats which have been retained and created. This will also be necessary to explain why the areas of retained grassland are not regularly cut, to prevent future conflict with residents.

Construction Handover

- 7.11 Upon completion of all planting, the development site will be signed off by the site manager and / or soft landscaping provider(s).

Management and Monitoring

- 7.12 Management of the onsite hedge, tree, grass and pond related habitat units will likely be secured by the HMMP, and monitored in the long term as part of this HMMP.
- 7.13 Management of offsite habitat units will also be secured by an HMMP, and monitored in the long term as part of this HMMP.
- 7.14 The hedge, tree, grass and pond related habitats will be subject to a UKHab condition assessment by a suitably experienced ecologist in Years 2 and 5, and then every 5 years thereafter. The results of the condition assessment will inform the ongoing management of these features, and where the stated condition is not achieved and / or maintained, management prescriptions and the timing of future condition assessments will be altered accordingly.
- 7.15 Organising and implementing monitoring will most likely be the responsibility of the management company.



8.0 REFERENCES

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Appendix 1:

Site Layout





132 dwellings under
20/01416/DETAIL

0 10 20 30 40 50
metres
SCALE BAR 1:500

GENERAL NOTES

1. Dimensions are in millimetres (unless stated otherwise) and are to block or stud faces.
2. Drawings are not to be scaled, use figured dimensions only.
3. Notify the Architect of any discrepancies within the drawing and contact for clarification before proceeding.
4. All proprietary items to be fitted strictly in accordance with manufacturers instructions.
5. All works to be carried out in accordance with latest related British Standards and relevant codes of practice.

- 1 New vehicular access point with 90 metre vision splay shown
- 2 Minor Access combined pedestrian/vehicular access 5.8 metres wide.
- 3 Type 3 Turn
- 4 550m² swale Suds feature
- 5 Blue dashed line shows pedestrian walking route around site perimeter - with active frontage address. Blue circles show link points to internal footpath infrastructure or to external footpaths and green spaces.
- 6 **29 dwellings shown:** mix of apartments; detached; semi-detached; 2, 3, 4 bedrooms; each with min. 100m² private amenity space, each with 2 no. parking spaces 2.9m x 5.5m, most with associated cartlodge or garage provision. Visitor parking spaces also shown.

Rev	Date	Revision Description
Project Title		
Scale		1:500 @ A2
Project Ref.		3735
Drawing Ref.		PA-10
Drawing Title		
Date Drawn		MAY 2025
Drawn By		CR
Checked By		CR
SITE PLAN PROPOSED		

DUNCAN CLARK & BECKETT LTD
12A William's Walk, Colchester, Essex, CO1 1TS
RIBA Chartered Practice
CIAT Chartered Practice

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OUTLINE PLANNING APPLICATION ISSUE

Appendix 2:
Condition Assessment Sheets

Other neutral grassland

Condition Sheet: GRASSLAND Habitat Type (medium, high and very high distinctiveness)			
UK Habitat Classification (UKHab) Habitat Types			
Grassland - Lowland calcareous grassland Grassland - Lowland dry acid grassland Grassland - Lowland meadows Grassland - Other lowland acid grassland Grassland - Other neutral grassland Grassland - Tall herb communities (H6430) [Not to be confused with the Tall forbs secondary code – see UKHab guidance for details.] Grassland - Upland acid grassland Grassland - Upland calcareous grassland Grassland - Upland hay meadows Sparsely vegetated land - Calaminarian grassland			
On-site or off-site, site name and location	Onsite - Sladburys Lane, Little Clacton	Survey date and Surveyor name	23rd Sept 2024, Liz Lord
Limitations (if applicable)		Survey reference (if relating to a wider survey)	
Grid reference	TM 19058 16846	Habitat parcel reference	1
Habitat Description			
Other neutral grassland. Grass cover at c.70% - a relatively even mix of red fescue (O-F), perennial ryegrass (O-F), false oat grass (F), smaller cats tail (O-F), creeping bent (O-F), crested dogs tail (O) and Yorkshire fog (O). Variable moss cover at ground level. Forbs averaged around 30% cover, ranging from 15-40%. Species per m ² generally between five and eight, dominated by knapweed (F), creeping thistle (O-F), ribwort plantain (O), red clover (O), common ragwort (O) and birds foot trefoil (O).			
ukhab – UK Habitat Classification			
Condition Assessment Criteria		Criterion passed (Yes or No)	Notes (such as justification)
A	The parcel represents a good example of its habitat type, with a consistently high proportion of characteristic indicator species present relevant to the specific habitat type (and relative to Footnote 3 suboptimal species which may be listed in the UKHab description). ¹ Note - this criterion is essential for achieving Moderate or Good condition for non-acid grassland types only.	Yes	Good number of grassland indicator species and relative widespread abundance of forb indicator species
B	Sward height is varied (at least 20% of the sward is less than 7 cm and at least 20% is more than 7 cm) creating microclimates which provide opportunities for insects, birds and small mammals to live and breed.	No	Uniformly cut at time of survey
C	Cover of bare ground is between 1% and 5%, including localised areas, for example, rabbit warrens ² .	Yes	
D	Cover of bracken <i>Pteridium aquilinum</i> is less than 20% and cover of scrub (including bramble <i>Rubus fruticosus</i> agg.) is less than 5%.	Yes	Very little present, limited to occasional blackthorn suckers in northern corner

E	Combined cover of species indicative of suboptimal condition³ and physical damage (such as excessive poaching, damage from machinery use or storage, damaging levels of access, or any other damaging management activities) accounts for less than 5% of total area. If any invasive non-native plant species⁴ (as listed on Schedule 9 of WCA⁵) are present, this criterion is automatically failed.	No	Creeping thistle cover >5%
Additional Criterion - must be assessed for all non-acid grassland types			
F	There are 10 or more vascular plant species per m² present, including forbs that are characteristic of the habitat type (species referenced in Footnote 3 and 5 cannot contribute towards this count). Note - this criterion is essential for achieving Good condition for non-acid grassland types only.	No	Species per square metre generally between 5 and 8
Essential criterion for Good condition achieved (for non-acid grassland) (Yes or No)		No	
Number of criteria passed		3	
Condition Assessment Result	Condition Assessment Score	Score Achieved x/√	
Acid grassland types (Result out of 5 criteria)			
Passes 5 criteria	Good (3)		
Passes 3 or 4 criteria	Moderate (2)		
Passes 2 or fewer criteria	Poor (1)		
Non-acid grassland types (Result out of 6 criteria)			
Passes 5 or 6 criteria, including essential criterion A and additional criterion F.	Good (3)		
Passes 3 - 5 criteria, including essential criterion A.	Moderate (2)	X	
Passes 2 or fewer criteria; OR Passes 3 or 4 criteria excluding criterion A and F.	Poor (1)		
Suggested enhancement interventions to improve condition score			
Improved management as a hay meadow - cut and remove in late summer, followed by low density autumn and spring grazing (or cutting and removing vegetation where grazing not possible). Spot treat or hand pull all thistles. Leave some strips / margins uncut on rotation every other year to improve structural diversity			
Notes			
Footnote 1 - Professional judgement should be used alongside the UKHab description. Footnote 2 – For example, this could include small, scattered areas of bare ground allowing for plant colonisation, or localised patches not exceeding 5% cover. Footnote 3 - Species indicative of suboptimal condition for this habitat type include: creeping thistle <i>Cirsium arvense</i>, spear thistle <i>Cirsium vulgare</i>, curled dock <i>Rumex crispus</i>, broad-leaved dock <i>Rumex obtusifolius</i>, common nettle <i>Urtica dioica</i>, creeping buttercup <i>Ranunculus repens</i>, greater plantain <i>Plantago major</i>, white clover <i>Trifolium repens</i> and cow parsley <i>Anthriscus sylvestris</i>. There may be additional relevant species local to the region and or site. Footnote 4 – Assess this for each distinct habitat parcel. If the distribution of invasive non-native species varies across the habitat, split into parcels accordingly, applying a buffer zone around the invasive non-native species with a size relative to its risk of spread into adjacent habitat, by applying professional judgement. Footnote 5 – Wildlife and Countryside Act 1981 (as amended).			

Ruderal / ephemeral

Condition Sheet: URBAN Habitat Type			
Habitat Types			
Sparsely vegetated land - Ruderal/Ephemeral Sparsely vegetated land - Tall forbs Urban - Allotments Urban - Biodiverse green roof Urban - Bioswale Urban - Cemeteries and churchyards Urban - Facade-bound green wall Urban - Ground based green wall Urban - Intensive green roof Urban - Open mosaic habitats on previously developed land Urban - Rain garden Urban - Sustainable drainage system (SuDS) Urban - Vacant or derelict land Urban - Bare ground			
Habitat Description			
Large mound of earth and small hardcore 3-4m tall, likely associated with the construction of housing immediately offsite to the west. The mound has become partially colonised with ruderal / ephemeral species dominated by fat hen, with some sow thistle, fumitory, bristly oxtongue, musk mallow, yarrow and black nightshade.			
See the Statutory Biodiversity Metric User Guide for green roofs and UK Habitat Classification (UKHab) for other habitats:			UKHab – UK Habitat Classification
On-site or off-site, site name and location	Onsite - Sladburys Lane, Little Clacton	Survey date and Surveyor name	23rd Sept 2024, Liz Lord
Limitations (if applicable)		Survey reference (if relating to a wider survey)	
Grid reference	TM 19041 16790	Habitat parcel reference	2
Condition Assessment Criteria		Criterion passed (Yes or No)	Notes (such as justification)
Core Criteria - must be assessed for all urban habitat types :			
A	Vegetation structure is varied, providing opportunities for vertebrates and invertebrates to live, eat and breed. A single structural habitat component or vegetation type does not account for more than 80% of the total habitat area.	No	c.60% of vegetation cover is fat hen, with the remaining veg'n also broad leaved & similarly sparse at ground level
B	The habitat parcel contains different plant species that are beneficial for wildlife, for example flowering species providing nectar sources for a range of invertebrates at different times of year.	Yes	Fat hen, sow thistle, fumitory, bristly oxtongue, musk mallow, yarrow and black nightshade
C	Invasive non-native plant species (listed on Schedule 9 of WCA ¹) and others which are to the detriment of native wildlife (using professional judgement) ² cover less than 5% of the total vegetated area ³ . Note - to achieve Good condition, this criterion must be satisfied by a complete absence of invasive non-native species (rather than <5% cover).	Yes	None present
Additional Criterion - must be assessed for Open mosaic habitat on previously developed land only:			
D	The parcel shows spatial variation and forms a mosaic of bare substrate PLUS: - At least four early successional communities (a) to (i); Communities: (a) annuals; (b) mosses/liverworts; (c) lichens; (d) ruderals; (e) inundation species; (f) open grassland; (g) flower-rich grassland; (h) heathland, (i) pools.	N/A	N/A
Additional Criteria - must be assessed for Bioswale and SuDS habitat types only:			
E1	Plant species are mostly native. If non-native species are present, they should not be detrimental to the habitat or native wildlife ⁴ .	N/A	N/A
E2	The vegetation is comprised of plant species suited to wetland or riparian situations.	N/A	N/A
Additional Criterion - must be assessed for Intensive green roofs only:			

F	The roof has a minimum of 50% native and non-native wildflowers. 70% of the roof area is soil and vegetation (including water features).	N/A	N/A
Additional Criterion - must be assessed for Biodiverse green roofs only:			
G	The roof has a varied depth of 80 – 150 mm; at least 50% is at 150 mm and is planted and seeded with wildflowers and sedums or is pre-prepared with sedums and wildflowers. Note – to achieve Good condition some additional habitat, such as sand piles, stones, logs etc. are present.	N/A	N/A
Essential criteria relevant for habitat type achieved (Yes or No)			Yes
Number of criteria passed			2
Condition Assessment Result		Condition Assessment Score	Score Achieved x/✓
Results for habitats requiring assessment of 3 core criteria only (all listed urban habitats except Open mosaic habitat on previously developed land, Bioswale, SuDS and Green roofs):			
• Passes all 3 core criteria; AND • Meets the requirements for Good condition within criterion C.		Good (3)	
• Passes 2 of 3 core criteria; OR • Passes 3 of 3 core criteria but does not meet the requirements for Good condition within criterion C.		Moderate (2)	X
• Passes 0 or 1 of 3 core criteria.		Poor (1)	
Results for Green roofs and Open mosaic habitat on previously developed land (requiring assessment of 4 criteria only - core criteria plus additional criterion specified for habitat type):			
• Passes all 3 core criteria; AND • Meets the requirements for Good condition within criterion C; AND • Passes additional criterion relevant to specific habitat type (D, F or G).		Good (3)	
• Passes 2 or 3 of 4 criteria; OR • Passes 4 of 4 criteria but does not meet the requirements for Good condition within criterion C.		Moderate (2)	
• Passes 0 or 1 of 4 criteria.		Poor (1)	
Results for Bioswale or SuDS (requiring assessment of 5 criteria - core criteria plus additional criteria specified for habitat type):			
• Passes all 3 core criteria; AND • Meets the requirements for Good condition within criterion C; AND • Passes all additional criteria relevant to specific habitat type (Group E)		Good (3)	
• Passes 3 or 4 of 5 criteria; OR • Passes 5 of 5 criteria but does not meet the requirements for Good condition within criterion C.		Moderate (2)	
• Passes 2 or fewer of 5 criteria.		Poor (1)	
Suggested enhancement interventions to improve condition score			
Footnotes			

Other neutral grassland

Condition Sheet: GRASSLAND Habitat Type (medium, high and very high distinctiveness)			
UK Habitat Classification (UKHab) Habitat Types			
Grassland - Lowland calcareous grassland Grassland - Lowland dry acid grassland Grassland - Lowland meadows Grassland - Other lowland acid grassland Grassland - Other neutral grassland Grassland - Tall herb communities (H6430) [Not to be confused with the Tall forbs secondary code – see UKHab guidance for details.] Grassland - Upland acid grassland Grassland - Upland calcareous grassland Grassland - Upland hay meadows Sparsely vegetated land - Calaminarian grassland			
On-site or off-site, site name and location	Onsite - Sladburys Lane, Little Clacton	Survey date and Surveyor name	23rd Sept 2024, Liz Lord
Limitations (if applicable)		Survey reference (if relating to a wider survey)	
Grid reference	TM 19109 16810	Habitat parcel reference	5
Habitat Description			
An area of variable vegetation cover resulting from disturbance during laying of parking materials and heras fencing. Vegetation comprises occasional grasses such as false oat grass, plus frequent creeping thistle, knapweed, bristly oxtongue, mugwort and areas of bracken, bramble and blackthorn growing along the road boundary. Habitat categorised as Tall Forbs (secondary code), but with a grassland primary code as the most appropriate fit. Veg'n cover is not sparse throughout, so cannot be categorised as Tall Forbs in the Sparsely Vegetated Land category ukhab – UK Habitat Classification			
Condition Assessment Criteria		Criterion passed (Yes or No)	Notes (such as justification)
A	The parcel represents a good example of its habitat type, with a consistently high proportion of characteristic indicator species present relevant to the specific habitat type (and relative to Footnote 3 suboptimal species which may be listed in the UKHab description). ¹ Note - this criterion is essential for achieving Moderate or Good condition for non-acid grassland types only.	No	Low abundance of both grassland and forb indicator species
B	Sward height is varied (at least 20% of the sward is less than 7 cm and at least 20% is more than 7 cm) creating microclimates which provide opportunities for insects, birds and small mammals to live and breed.	No	All vegetation is uncut
C	Cover of bare ground is between 1% and 5%, including localised areas, for example, rabbit warrens ² .	Yes	
D	Cover of bracken <i>Pteridium aquilinum</i> is less than 20% and cover of scrub (including bramble <i>Rubus fruticosus</i> agg.) is less than 5%.	No	Patches of sparse bramble and blackthorn scrub >5% cover

E	Combined cover of species indicative of suboptimal condition³ and physical damage (such as excessive poaching, damage from machinery use or storage, damaging levels of access, or any other damaging management activities) accounts for less than 5% of total area. If any invasive non-native plant species⁴ (as listed on Schedule 9 of WCA⁵) are present, this criterion is automatically failed.	No	Creeping thistle cover and ground disturbance from car park construction >5%
Additional Criterion - must be assessed for all non-acid grassland types			
F	There are 10 or more vascular plant species per m² present, including forbs that are characteristic of the habitat type (species referenced in Footnote 3 and 5 cannot contribute towards this count). Note - this criterion is essential for achieving Good condition for non-acid grassland types only.	No	Most plant species present are not characteristic of the habitat type
Essential criterion for Good condition achieved (for non-acid grassland) (Yes or No)		No	
Number of criteria passed		1	
Condition Assessment Result	Condition Assessment Score	Score Achieved x/√	
Acid grassland types (Result out of 5 criteria)			
Passes 5 criteria	Good (3)		
Passes 3 or 4 criteria	Moderate (2)		
Passes 2 or fewer criteria	Poor (1)		
Non-acid grassland types (Result out of 6 criteria)			
Passes 5 or 6 criteria, including essential criterion A and additional criterion F.	Good (3)		
Passes 3 - 5 criteria, including essential criterion A.	Moderate (2)		
Passes 2 or fewer criteria; OR Passes 3 or 4 criteria excluding criterion A and F.	Poor (1)	X	
Suggested enhancement interventions to improve condition score			
Notes			
Footnote 1 - Professional judgement should be used alongside the UKHab description. Footnote 2 – For example, this could include small, scattered areas of bare ground allowing for plant colonisation, or localised patches not exceeding 5% cover. Footnote 3 - Species indicative of suboptimal condition for this habitat type include: creeping thistle <i>Cirsium arvense</i>, spear thistle <i>Cirsium vulgare</i>, curled dock <i>Rumex crispus</i>, broad-leaved dock <i>Rumex obtusifolius</i>, common nettle <i>Urtica dioica</i>, creeping buttercup <i>Ranunculus repens</i>, greater plantain <i>Plantago major</i>, white clover <i>Trifolium repens</i> and cow parsley <i>Anthriscus sylvestris</i>. There may be additional relevant species local to the region and or site. Footnote 4 – Assess this for each distinct habitat parcel. If the distribution of invasive non-native species varies across the habitat, split into parcels accordingly, applying a buffer zone around the invasive non-native species with a size relative to its risk of spread into adjacent habitat, by applying professional judgement. Footnote 5 – Wildlife and Countryside Act 1981 (as amended).			

Individual rural tree

Condition Sheet: INDIVIDUAL TREES Habitat Type			
Habitat Types			
Individual trees – Urban trees Individual trees – Rural trees Complete a condition sheet for each tree or block of trees.			
<i>Please see the separate Line of trees condition sheet for a line of <u>rural</u> trees. You should only use the Line of trees condition assessment and record that habitat type in <u>rural</u> locations.</i>			
Habitat Description			
A mature multi-stemmed field maple; noted to have a small number of crevices due to overlapping stems, but little deadwood			
Individual trees (description applied to the urban or rural environment): Young trees over 7.5 cm in diameter at breast height whose canopies are not touching.			
Urban Perimeter / Linear Blocks and Groups (description applied to the urban environment only): Groups or stands of trees (size requirement as defined above) within and around the perimeter of urban land. This includes those along urban streets, highways, railways and canals, and also former field boundary trees incorporated into developments. Canopies should predominantly overlap continuously. Groups of urban trees that don't match the descriptions for woodland may be assessed within this category.			
On-site or off-site, site name and location	Onsite - Sladbury's Lane, Little Clacton	Survey date and Surveyor name	23rd September 2024, Liz Lord
Limitations (if applicable)		Survey reference (if relating to a wider survey)	
Grid reference	TM1910516795	Habitat parcel reference	T1
Condition Assessment Criteria		Criterion passed (Yes or No)	Notes (such as justification)
A	The tree is a native species (or at least 70% within the block are native species).	Yes	Field maple
B	The tree canopy is predominantly continuous, with gaps in canopy cover making up <10% of total area and no individual gap being >5 m wide (individual trees automatically pass this criterion).	Yes	Individual tree, with good canopy cover
C	The tree is mature (or more than 50% within the block are mature) ¹ .	Yes	Mature
D	There is little or no evidence of an adverse impact on tree health by human activities (such as vandalism, herbicide or detrimental agricultural activity). And there is no current regular pruning regime, so the trees retain >75% of expected canopy for their age range and height.	Yes	None recorded
E	Natural ecological niches for vertebrates and invertebrates are present, such as presence of deadwood, cavities, ivy or loose bark.	Yes	No deadwood cavities, but multiple overlapping stems creating crevices
F	More than 20% of the tree canopy area is oversailing vegetation beneath.	Yes	Ruderal vegetation
Number of criteria passed		6	
Condition Assessment Result (out of 6 criteria)	Condition Assessment Score	Score Achieved x1/✓	
Passes 5 or 6 criteria	Good (3)	X	
Passes 3 or 4 criteria	Moderate (2)		
Passes 2 or fewer criteria	Poor (1)		
Note that 'Fairly Good and Fairly Poor' condition categories are not available for this broad habitat type.			
Suggested enhancement interventions to improve condition score²			

Appendix 3:
Site Photographs

Site Photographs



Photo 1: Road into site, with grassland to north and parking area to south



Photo 2: Compacted hardcore and earth parking area



Photo 3: Stored materials and earth / rubble near close to western boundary



Photo 4: Mature offsite pollard oak tree along western boundary / western side of grassland



Photo 5: Central area of grassland, looking north west



Photo 6: Eastern side of grassland, looking north east



Photo 7: Grassland viewed from west to east



Photo 8: Typical view of grassland, with frequent large clumps of knapweed, thistle regrowth, ribwort plantain and grass regrowth



Photo 9: Western boundary



Photo 10: North western boundary hedge with trees



Photo 11: North eastern boundary hedge (no trees)



Photo 12: South eastern road verge with ruderal vegetation and mature multi-stemmed field maple



Liz Lord Ecology

